Eastern and western timing

iAngels · by Jikara and Graham

A natal chart places the Sun, the Moon, and the planets on a circle of twelve signs. Eastern and western timing use the same birth date, the same time, and the same place. They disagree about where the signs begin.

Western timing

Western timing measures the signs from the seasons. Aries begins at the March equinox, when the Sun crosses the equator heading north. Cancer begins at the June solstice, Libra at the September equinox, and Capricorn at the December solstice. The signs stay locked to the year. Aries remains the sign of spring in the northern hemisphere. This is the zodiac of most astrology written in Europe and the Americas. Astronomers mark the start of spring with that same equinox. That fact does not decide which astrology to follow.

Eastern timing

Eastern timing measures the signs from the stars. The offset used for it is Lahiri, the standard of the Indian astronomical almanac. It holds the signs to the fixed stars, so that Spica, called Chitra, stays near the beginning of Libra. The March equinox slides west along the stars by about one degree every seventy-two years. The two circles are now about twenty-four degrees apart. The Sun moves about one degree a day, so it needs twenty-five days to cross that gap. People often call the difference three weeks.

Why the birth date stays put

The birth date is not moved by those three weeks. Every point on the chart is set back by the same angle, about twenty-four degrees. The Moon crosses a sign in a little more than two days. Moving the birthday by three weeks would throw the Moon almost around the sky, and it would give the Ascendant a different hour. Moving every position by the same angle does neither. A planet keeps its house. A planet near the end of a western sign often stands at the start of the previous eastern sign.

Strengths and limits of western timing

The signs keep the meaning of the seasons. Two people born on the same day of the year, a generation apart, still share a western Sun sign. The limit is that the signs no longer cover the constellations they were named for. The Sun in western Aries is not among the stars of the constellation Aries.

Strengths and limits of eastern timing

The signs stay with the stars. That is the frame of Indian astrology, called Jyotish. It answers the worry that a chart has fallen a month away from the constellations. The limit is that the seasons no longer sit neatly on the sign names, and a Sun sign may differ from a newspaper. Much eastern practice uses whole-sign houses, one sign to a house. A change of timing moves the signs. It does not by itself make a full Jyotish reading.

A choice

These are two rulers on one sky. Each is consistent inside its own tradition. Use the timing whose tradition you want the chart to follow.